



THE COUNT'S RING

A Dungeons & Dragons 5e adventure

dracoroboter

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The Count's Ring

humorous

D&D 5e (2014)

Level 1

Duration: campaign (5+ episodes)

Structure: linear

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△ Auto-translated from Italian. The Italian version is the source of truth.

The Count's Ring

Introduction

The realm of Drakenhold is enjoying its most radiant season. In the south of the realm, the village of **Fianus Romanus** - a sun-kissed hamlet surrounded by fertile lands - is the kind of place where nothing important ever happens. At least until **Sir Gorim Vel**, the Count's official, decides it's time to recruit a group of adventurers for a mission "of capital importance": finding **l'Anello del Conte** (the Count's Ring).

Nobody knows what the Ring is. Nobody knows what it does. Nobody knows where it is. And nobody knows the Count's name.

Welcome to Fianus Romanus.

General Plot

The PCs are hired by Sir Gorim Vel to recover the Count's Ring, which fell into the sewers of Fianus Romanus. They descend into the sewers and find only a mocking letter: someone - signed "S" - took the Ring before them and promises to show up at the Festa del Grazie. Gorim pays half the fee and binds them to him for the follow-up.

Concept

A D&D 5e (2014) episodic adventure, inspired by the Italian comedy series **Boris**. Humorous tone without going overboard: absurd situations treated seriously by the characters. Bureaucracy, incompetence, oversized egos. Structured as "episodes" like a TV season.

The adventure is the **prologue** to the serious campaign **Il Re Spezzato** (The Broken King). The Count is a local noble, not King Dorian Valemarch. In the final episode, just as the PCs are about to meet him and earn honor and glory, the Count dies in an explosion. No answers, no reward, no name. The Count's death and the ensuing chaos are the hook that drags the PCs into the larger story of Drakenhold and Il Re Spezzato.

PC Level: 1 (with progression during episodes)

Lore

Drakenhold - The name refers to both the **realm** and its **capital**, at the center of the continent. Ruled by **King Dorian Valemarch**.

Fianus Romanus - A village in southern Drakenhold, connected to the capital. Surrounded by fertile lands, it faces the sea to the south (like Ostia to Rome). Governed by the Count - a vassal of Dorian whose name nobody knows. Rural life, trade, traditions. Everyone knows everyone, everyone gossips, nobody works as much as they should. It has surprisingly elaborate sewers for a village of this size (nobody knows why). The population is almost entirely human - other races are rare and attract curiosity.

Available maps: `maps/RealmOfAmrog` (region), `maps/FianusRomanus` (village), `01_LeFogneDiFianus/maps/LeFogneDiFianus` (dungeon quest 1).

The PCs

The PCs are broke adventurers living in Fianus Romanus. Poverty is the narrative engine: they take on adventures to scrape together lunch and dinner.

Rule: each PC starts with **5 silver pieces**. Nothing else.

Main NPCs

Full sheets are in `characters/`.

Sir Gorim Vel

Fighter 3 (Defence) - The René Ferretti of Fianus Romanus

The Count's official, sent to manage the village. Stocky, exasperated, gesticulates with a scroll in hand. Tries to complete the mission with the resources he has - namely the PCs. He's not happy about it. He's the only NPC with direct (though vague) contact with the Count.

Recurring phrases: "Come on come on come on, we can do this", "Splendid. Wonderful." (sarcastic), "What are you doing?!", "I can't take it anymore with you lot".

→ Full sheet: `characters/NPC_SirGorimVel.md`

The Count

Noble - The living MacGuffin

Nobody knows his name. Nobody has seen his face. The only known fact is that he's a vassal of King Dorian Valemarch. He governs Fianus Romanus through letters, decrees, and messengers. His orders are often contradictory. In the final episode, just as the PCs are about to meet him, he dies in an explosion. No name, no face, no answers. His death and the power vacuum that follows are the hook toward Il Re Spezzato.

→ Full sheet: `characters/NPC_IlConte.md`

Running Gag

The Count's Name

Every time an NPC is about to say the Count's name, they get interrupted:

- A deafening noise that covers the word
- A sneeze
- Something collapsing
- "The Count... what's his name... wait, it's on the tip of my tongue..."
- Official letters have the seal but the signature is illegible
- An NPC swears they know it but wants to be paid first - then doesn't know it either

The Ring

Everyone talks about it, nobody knows what it does, nobody knows where it is:

- Every NPC has a different and incompatible theory
- Someone swears they've seen it (it was an onion ring)
- Gorim is convinced the PCs already know everything
- It's only found in the final episode, where "everything will be clear to everyone"

Boris Parallels

Boris	L'Anello del Conte
"The show" (Gli Occhi del Cuore) nobody understands	"The mission" (finding the Ring) nobody understands
René Ferretti	Sir Gorim Vel
Stanis La Rochelle	Pipinius Chennedius (PC)
Duccio	Gin Tonica (PC)
Corinna	Maria Biscanna (PC)
"Daje!"	Recurring village exclamation (TBD)
"Smarmella tutto"	Fantasy equivalent (TBD)

Future Hooks

Elements to seed during the comedic episodes:

- Gorim sometimes stops mid-sentence, worried about things that go beyond local incompetence
- The Count receives orders from someone higher up (the King?) - vague hints
- Nearby there's an abandoned mine (Nerrok) that "nobody wants to visit"
- The Count's death in the final episode isn't comedic - it's the moment the comedy ends
- Gorim receives an urgent message from the capital after the explosion: the King wants to see him
- The power vacuum left by the Count drags the PCs into the larger story of Drakenhold

Gorim's Arc (SPOILER - DM only)

After the explosion that kills the Count, Gorim changes. He's no longer the exasperated official - he's a man who lost his lord and couldn't do anything about it. Between L'Anello del Conte and Il Re Spezzato, **one year** passes. In that year Gorim is summoned to court and becomes King Dorian Valemarch's confidant and servant. When the PCs find him again in Il Re Spezzato, he's a different man: serious, weary, loyal to the bone. The contrast with the comedic Gorim from L'Anello del Conte is the strongest signal that the tone has changed.

During the comedic episodes, seed small moments where Gorim shows a loyalty and sense of duty that go beyond the gag - these are the traits that Dorian will notice and that will lead him to choose Gorim as his confidant.

Adventure Structure

Episode 1 - “Le Fogne di Fianus” (The Sewers of Fianus)

The PCs arrive in Fianus Romanus, get recruited by Gorim, and the first lead takes them into the village sewers. → [01_LeFogneDiFianus/](#)

Episode 2 - “La Festa del Grazie” (The Village Festival)

Fianus Romanus celebrates the Festa del Grazie. Sergius, disguised as an official, gives a public speech with veiled accusations against the Count, then launches a treasure hunt through the village. The PCs discover the vigor potion trade and the existence of a compromising portrait of the Count.

Episode 3 - “Il Rivale” (The Rival) (to be developed)

Another group of adventurers arrives, sent by the Count for the same mission. Comedic competition.

Episode 4 - “La Pista Vera (forse)” (The Real Lead (maybe)) (to be developed)

A lead takes them outside the village. A merchant of counterfeit rings. A real clue the PCs don't recognize.

Episode 5 - “Il Finale di Stagione” (The Season Finale) (to be developed)

The PCs are finally about to meet the Count. Explosion. The Count dies. No name, no face, no Ring, no answers. The chaos that follows drags them toward Il Re Spezzato.

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Episode 1 - The Sewers of Fianus

Description

The PCs are recruited by Sir Gorim Vel at the Taberna of Fianus Romanus to recover the Count's Ring from the village sewers. The Ring isn't there - they'll find a mocking letter that launches them toward Episode 2.

Objective

Stated: Find the Count's Ring in the sewers and bring it back to Gorim. **Actual:** The Ring isn't there. The PCs find a letter from "S" pointing to the Festa del Grazie.

Intro - The Taberna

Read to the players

*The realm of Drakenhold is enjoying its most radiant season. In the south, the village of **Fianus Romanus** - a sun-kissed hamlet surrounded by fertile lands - dozes between rural traditions and modest trade. Life flows peacefully, or so it seems.*

*You arrived here for your own reasons - a delivery, a debt, a more or less voluntary exile - and found yourselves sitting at the **Taberna de Franciosibus aut Hispanardis**, the only tavern in Fianus Romanus.*

*The sign depicts a boar lying on its side with an expression of blissful satisfaction. The interior lives up to the promise: sticky tables, a fireplace that produces more smoke than heat, hams hanging from the ceiling at dangerous proximity to patrons' heads, and a permanent smell of spilled wine and aged cheese. The tavern keeper - a massive woman who answers only to "**Domina Lella**" - serves enormous portions and unsolicited opinions. The house wine is red, strong, and nobody knows which vineyard it comes from. Best not to ask.*

*This morning, however, Domina Lella isn't serving anything. Domina Lella wants her money. She's still owed **July's rent**, and she's reminding you with a volume and frequency that has silenced the entire tavern. A finger thick as a sausage points at you from behind the bar: "Either you pay, or you sleep in the street. And don't think about running - I'll find you."*

It's at this moment - while you desperately search for the right words to calm her down - that a stocky man in a green cloak, scroll in hand, enters the tavern. He looks around. His eyes land on you - the only ones in the whole place who look like they own a weapon, or at least know which end to hold.

He approaches, sizes you up more carefully, and his face lights up:

"But... but you're...!"

DM Notes - The Mistaken Identity

Gorim is convinced he recognizes the PCs as famous adventurers. He calls them by name - wrong names, of heroes they're not:

- **Female:** "Misty", "Gowen", "Enlet", "Diamante", "Giustina" or "Ludovica"
- **Male:** "Ander", "Goffredo" or "Draco"

Read to the players

“Diamante! The god-slayer of Westmarch! And you... Draco! The dragon-slayer of Passo di Nerrok! It’s an honor! An HONOR! I heard about your feat against the giants of the north - magnificent, magnificent!”

None of the PCs have ever done any of this.

DM Note: adapt names and feats to the PCs at the table. The example above is indicative - choose from the list based on character gender and invent absurd feats on the spot.

DM Notes - PC Reaction

If the PCs play along (no roll required, just don’t contradict him): Gorim is enthusiastic, treats them with deference, and the payment negotiation starts higher. Domina Lella eyes them suspiciously but stays quiet - if they’re really famous heroes, maybe the rent will come.

If the PCs get caught (or give themselves away, or are honest): Gorim darkens. *“Ah. You’re not... Ah.”* Pause. *“Well, you’ll do. Come with me. Count’s orders.”* The monetary offer drops further - it’ll start even lower in the negotiation.

The Scroll

DM Notes

The man is **Sir Gorim Vel**, the Count’s official - whose name nobody can pronounce. He unrolls a scroll and reads:

Read to the players

“Let it be known to whomever reads this proclamation that His Most Illustrious Excellency the Count of [ink stain], Lord of Fianus Romanus and faithful vassal of the Crown of Drakenhold, communicates with utmost regret and profound consternation that His most precious Ring - a relic of inestimable value and symbol of His august house - has been lost in circumstances as unfortunate as they were unforeseen, having slipped from His noble fingers and plummeted down the drain of His private latrine.

Therefore, the undersigned Sir Gorim Vel, envoy and trustee of His Excellency, is charged with recruiting a band of valorous adventurers, or at least available ones, so that they may descend into the village sewers and recover the aforementioned Ring, returning it intact and, if possible, clean.

The reward shall be commensurate with the value of the undertaking and the generosity of His Excellency, which is known to all, though no one has ever actually verified it.

Signed: [illegible signature]“

DM Note: the Count’s signature should be “read” aloud as an incomprehensible pronunciation, different every time. Gorim tries seriously but the result is always a different and nonsensical sound (“Signed... the Count of Brrglmfh... no, Prùgnacchio... wait, Thlòmpferd...”). Nobody corrects him because nobody knows how it’s actually pronounced. This gag should be repeated every time the Count’s signature appears in any document.

Gorim rolls up the scroll, looks at you, and says: “Good. Questions?”

DM Notes - PC Questions

The PCs will have questions. Gorim answers everything with growing impatience:

- **“What is the Ring?”** - *“The Count’s Ring. It’s a ring. The Count’s. What else do you need to know?”*
- **“What does it look like?”** - *“It’s a ring. Gold. With a seal. About this big.”*
(indicates a different size every time)
- **“Why is it in the sewers?”** - *“Because His Excellency had a... hygienic incident. Don’t ask questions.”*
- **“Who is the Count?”** - *“The Count is the Count. Your employer. Enough.”*
- **“What’s the Count’s name?”** - Gorim opens his mouth, stops, looks at the scroll, turns it over, and says: *“It’s written right here. Clearly.”* (it’s not written clearly)
- **“How much are you paying us?”** - Opens the negotiation (see below).

- **Any other question** - *“Yes yes, details. Let’s go, we’re running late.”*

When the questions run out (or Gorim loses patience), move to the negotiation.

The Negotiation

DM Notes

The PCs, who owe **3 gold pieces** in rent to Domina Lella (who’s standing right there listening with arms crossed), will inevitably ask: “And how much are you paying us?”

If the PCs haven’t been caught (Gorim still believes they’re famous heroes): starts at **30 gold pieces**. The PCs can negotiate up to 50.

If the PCs have been caught (or were honest): Gorim offers **1 gold piece**. One. The PCs owe 3 gp to Domina - the offer isn’t even enough to pay the debt.

If the PCs accept the 1 gp offer without negotiating, Domina Lella grabs a rolling pin from behind the bar and threatens to call the guards: *“ONE coin?! And how am I supposed to see my three gold pieces?! Either you negotiate better or I’m calling the guards and having you thrown in!”* The PCs are forced to negotiate.

A bargaining scene opens. Gorim takes offense, the PCs insist, Gorim brings up that “in my day adventurers did it for the glory”, the PCs respond that you can’t eat glory, Gorim sighs, counteroffers 5 gp, the PCs push back again... The scene can go on as long as the table is having fun.

Maximum result: 50 gold pieces, but only for recovering the Ring. Gorim specifies: *“50 gold pieces. FIFTY. But only if you bring me the ring.”*

When he actually has to pay (in later episodes), every payment is a comedic scene - see Gorim’s NPC sheet (§ Pathological Stinginess).

Gorim will pay half the sum since the ring won’t be found.

The Search for the Entrance

The ring fell into the Count’s latrine, so it must be searched for in the sewers. Gorim knows this and knows where the entrance is, but would prefer the PCs figure it out themselves - “If I have to do everything, what are you for?”

Locations in the village (see map [../maps/FianusRomanus](#)):

- The **Taberna de Franciosibus aut Hispanardis** is located at the **Mercato Centrale**, the village’s main square.

- The **Count's residence** is the largest building in the **Aviano** quarter. Closed and guarded - the Count is never there, but the guards pretend he is.
- The **sewer entrance** is a trapdoor in the **Settebagni** quarter, past **Ponte Milvius**. The trapdoor is covered by Terzilio's cart.
- **Terzilio the greengrocer** sells turnips and onions. He has a stall at the **Mercato Centrale** but lives in **Settebagni** (where to find him is left to the DM).
- The **guards** are stationed at the Count's residence in **Aviano**.

DM Notes - The PCs Are Locals

The PCs are broke adventurers who've been living in Fianus Romanus for a while. They already know each other and know the village. The first scene at the Taberna serves to introduce the characters to each other for the players (not the PCs). There's no need to explain where Settebagni is or what Ponte Milvio is - they know.

Domina Lella's Information

Domina Lella's information doesn't come all at once. It should be given at separate moments, in response to specific PC questions. Domina Lella wants at least a down payment on the rent (5 sp, or a drink offered, or a convincing promise - Persuasion DC 12) before she'll talk.

Read to the players

Domina Lella crosses her arms: "Money first. Then information."

DM Notes

After paying/convincing, Domina Lella answers questions one at a time:

- a) If they ask about the sewers:** > *"The sewers? Should be down in Settebagni."*
- b) If they ask how to find them, or who can help:** > *"Ask Terzilio, he's from there. Sells turnips and onions, you can find him here at the market too."*
- c) Casually, if the conversation continues:** > *"That one's always complaining that someone keeps moving his cart."*

Terzilio the greengrocer

DM Notes

A nervous little man who sells turnips and onions. Lives in Settebagni and has a parking spot for his cart near his home. If the PCs ask him to show them the alley, he'll accompany them but won't get too close.

Read to the players

"The cart! Every day I find it moved from my spot! Always to the same place, right nearby."

(if they ask him to come along) "I'm not going down there. You can hear noises."

The Guards at the Count's Residence

DM Notes

Two bored guards in front of the palace in Aviano. If the PCs try to enter the castle, they laugh in their faces. If they ask about the sewers, they know where the main entrance is - it's common knowledge, not a secret.

The PCs will probably want to go directly under the castle, since the Count's latrine is there. The guards confirm that the sewers run from Settebagni and reach under the castle - but the entrance is in Settebagni, not Aviano.

Read to the players

"Enter the castle? Haha. No."

"His Excellency's latrines? They drain westward, toward Settebagni. Like everything in this village."

"The sewer entrance is down in Settebagni, past Ponte Milvius. Everyone knows that."

The other guard adds: "Once I saw a rat this big come out of a trapdoor near the temple. This big." (exaggerates with hands)

If the PCs Can't Find the Entrance

DM Notes

After the PCs have wandered enough (or if the DM feels they're getting stuck), Gorim loses patience.

Read to the players

Gorim pulls out a crumpled map of the village and points to Settebagni: "Do I have to do everything myself? It's THERE. Down in Settebagni, past the bridge. There's a trapdoor. Find it. Come on come on come on."

The Trapdoor

DM Notes

Under Terzilio's cart there's an iron trapdoor (2sq / 3m / 10ft) with the village crest (a boar, of course). It's not locked - the padlock is rusted and opens with a firm pull (STR DC 8) or a sharp blow (AC 10).

Read to the players

An iron ladder descends into darkness. The smell is exactly what you'd expect. The ladder leads to a sewer pipe wide enough to walk through, but very low - you have to walk hunched over, the tallest nearly on all fours. The air is thick, humid, and smells exactly like what you'd expect from a pipe that collects the drainage of an entire village. A trickle of liquid flows at your feet. It's not water. Not exactly. There are constant dripping sounds, distant echoes, and the noise of little feet moving in the shadows. Every now and then something brushes against an ankle. The pipe opens into a circular room. Here the ceiling rises and you can finally stand upright.

Overview

The sewers of Fianus are surprisingly elaborate for a village of this size. Nobody knows who built them or why. They're a 5-room dungeon with a mix of constructed architecture and natural caverns.

Why the Ring is here and not under the castle: The sewers flow from east (Aviano, where the Count's castle is) toward west (Settebagni, where the entrance is). The current carried the Ring from the Count's latrine to these rooms, where Sergius found it.

The tunnel: From Room 1, a long tunnel heads east toward the castle. About 10 minutes of walking in dim light - dripping, echoes, rat noises, but nothing happens. The tunnel narrows progressively until it becomes impassable. The PCs can't reach the castle from here, but they understand that the sewers do connect Settebagni to Aviano.

Map: [maps/LeFogneDiFianus.png](#)

Room connections: Exploration isn't linear. From Room 1 the PCs can go to Room 2 (corridor above) or Room 3 (passage in the center). Room 4 is reachable from 3 and 5 (corridors on the right side of the map). Room 5 is accessible only through Room 4 (the door with the bureaucratic form). The PCs can explore in whatever order they prefer - the rooms work independently.

Tone: The problems are mundane but treated as epic. No real mortal danger - consequences are comedic (debts, embarrassments, ridiculous curses).

Estimated duration: 1-2 sessions (1-3 hours each).

The Rooms

Room 1 - The Flooded Entrance

Large circular hall with two connected areas (visible on the map). Stagnant water at ankle level, terrible smell.

Encounter: The Unionized Rats A group of giant rats (5x **Giant Rat**, MM p. 327) physically blocks the passage to room 2. They're lined up, motionless, and won't move. Their leader, an unusually large rat with a tiny hat - **Biascica** - squeaks in what seems like an organized manner. It's a picket line.

Each rat wears an accessory: one has a scarf, one a glove, one a little hat (the leader), one socks, one a neckerchief. These are clearly stolen items.

The PCs must decide quickly: force their way through or find another way.

- **Combat:** The PCs attack. The rats fight but flee after 2 of them are defeated. The survivors will return in room 3 to cause trouble.
- **Brute force (Athletics DC 10):** Push them aside physically. Works, but the rats will follow them hostilely for the rest of the dungeon.

- **Food/payment:** If a PC offers a food ration or 5 copper pieces, the leader nods and the rats move aside in an orderly fashion.
- **Speak with Animals / Sylvan:** The rats have formed a union and are demanding a "toll." If paid, they offer advice: "Don't trust the one in room 2." If a PC has Speak with Animals (or similar ability), the conversation can be much richer - the rats have opinions about everything and everyone in the sewers.

DM Note: The 5 unionized rats are recurring NPCs. They should be reused in later episodes (protest in the square at the Festa del Grazie, picket line in front of a shop, etc.). They're recognizable by their accessories.

Loot: Among the debris, an oxidized copper ring. It's not the Count's Ring. Gorim (if present) examines it and says "No. Next room."

Room 2 - The Sewer Sage

Natural cavern with stalactites and a raised dry area. Someone has placed a chair, a small table, and a candle there.

NPC: Ermolao "Il Profondo" A middle-aged man who lives in the sewers by choice. Former village accountant, he quit and moved down here "to find himself." Speaks cryptically but actually says obvious things.

- "The Ring you seek... is not where you think it is." (he knows nothing)
- "The Count... ah, the Count..." *dramatic pause* "...is a very important person." (end)
- If they ask the Count's name: "I knew it, I knew it... wait..." *falls asleep*

Insight DC 10: Ermolao knows absolutely nothing useful but genuinely believes he does.

Usefulness: If treated well, he draws a "map" of the sewers on a napkin. It's wrong, but correctly indicates that in room 5 there's "something important."

Room 3 - The Great Cavern (The Tax Collector Troll)

The largest central cavern on the map. Open space, natural columns, echo.

Encounter: Grunzio the Sewer Troll He's not a real troll (that would be too much for level 1 PCs). Use the stat block of an **Ogre** (MM p. 237) with the following modifications:

- HP reduced to 30 (instead of 59)
- Speaks Common (poorly)
- Not hostile by default

Grunzio has lived here for years and considers the sewers his home. He just wants someone to pay his back rent - 47 gold pieces and 3 copper, "exact exact." He doesn't know who to pay the rent to. He doesn't know why he has to pay it. But he's convinced he must.

If the PCs insist on violence - 3-phase escalation:

1. **First shove:** Grunzio pushes the nearest PC (no damage, the PC ends up on the ground in the filthy water). *"NO! Grunzio doesn't want! Talk! TALK!"*
2. **Second shove:** Grunzio grabs a PC and throws them against the wall (1d4 bludgeoning damage). *"ENOUGH! Grunzio not bad! YOU bad!"*
3. **Third time:** Grunzio strikes for real with his club - full Ogre damage (2d8+4). The PC probably goes down. Grunzio immediately stops, starts crying, kneels beside the wounded PC and clumsily tries to help. *"No no no no... Grunzio didn't mean to... Grunzio bad... forgive Grunzio..."* He tries to bandage them with a piece of his filthy tunic. Combat ends here - Grunzio won't attack again.

Peaceful options:

- **Persuasion DC 12:** Convince him the PCs are the tax collectors and the rent has been forgiven. Grunzio cries with joy and lets them pass.
- **Deception DC 10:** Tell him the rent is paid in room 5 and he should go there. Grunzio leaves the room.
- **Performance DC 13 (Pipinius?):** Singing him a song moves him and makes him friendly. He offers the PCs a "treasure": a bucket full of bottle caps.

Room 4 - The Bureaucratic Trap

Hexagonal constructed room, more polished than the others. A closed door with a mechanism.

Trap: The Form The door can't be opened by force or lockpicking. Next to it is a lectern with a form to fill out: "REQUEST FOR ACCESS TO THE NEXT ROOM - Form 7B/bis". It asks for:

- Full name of the applicant
- Reason for visit (max 3 words)
- Name of the Count (required field)
-

The "Name of the Count" field accepts any answer. The door opens regardless. But a flat, bureaucratic magical voice says: *"Missing the stamp."* Nothing else happens. The door is open. If the PCs go back to look for a stamp, they waste time - no stamp exists. If they ignore it and proceed, everything's fine. Purely psychological trap.

The form is magically filed in a basket near the door.

Investigation DC 12: The form has been filled out hundreds of times. Each entry has a different name for the Count. No two are the same.

DM Notes - Previously Filled Forms (table)

If the PCs examine the forms in the basket, read randomly from the table. Also useful if the DM needs to improvise a Count's name on the fly.

#	Applicant Name	Reason for Visit	Count's Name
1	Terzilio Rapacini	Turnip delivery	Count Brumaldo di Fianus
2	Anonymous	Curiosity	Count Goffredo il Pallido
3	Ermolao (illegible)	Finding myself	Count Thlòmperfd
4	Guard no. 3	Superior's orders	Count Prùgnacchio
5	Maria the washerwoman	Laundry retrieval	Count Brrglmfh
6	Nobody	Nobody	Count Nobody
7	Pipinius (crossed out and rewritten 3 times)	Performance	Count Magnifico
8	A rat (paw print)	-	- (paw print)
9	Sergius S.	Business	(field left blank)
10	The Count himself	Inspection	(ink stain identical to the scroll)

Room 5 - The "Treasure" Room

Constructed room, relatively clean - too clean compared to the rest of the sewers. In the center, a pedestal with a chest. But that's not all: along the walls there are **open wooden crates**, some empty, others with packing straw residue. The floor is marked with **recent boot prints** - someone comes here regularly. These aren't monster prints: they're men's boots, of good quality.

Investigation DC 12: The crates have a brand burned into the side - a double interlocking S (like a dollar sign), the same seal as the chest.

Investigation DC 15: The crates contain only packing straw. But from the shape of the impressions in the straw and the size of the crates, the PC can intuit the general type of merchandise contained - medium-sized objects, probably individually wrapped. (The DM decides what they are when defining Sergius's trade.)

This room is **Sergius Arimano's** warehouse - the place where he collects his merchandise before selling it. The PCs don't know this yet, but the double S will return.

The Chest Open, no trap. The seal isn't the Count's - it's an unknown seal, a double interlocking S (the mark of Sergius Arimano, which the PCs won't recognize yet).

Inside:

- A letter
- A pouch with 15 silver pieces and a note: *"For you ragamuffins."*
- A dried onion ring (not the Count's Ring)

The Letter: *"Were you looking for something? Too bad. I got here first. Your master's ring is safe - cleaner than when I found it, I assure you. If he wants it back, he'll have to do much better than sending rats into the sewers to look for it. At the Festa del Grazie, perhaps, there'll be something for you. Or perhaps not. Depends on how much you amuse me. - S."*

The letter is the hook for Episode 2 and the first clue to the existence of Sergius Arimano.

Rewards

Dungeon Loot

- **Gold:** 15 sp (in the pouch with the note *"For you ragamuffins"*)
 - **Items:** Oxidized copper ring (value: 1 cp), dried onion ring (value: edible), sealed letter
 - **Information:** The Count's name has been written in hundreds of different ways (room 4). The Ring isn't in the sewers - someone took it before them. The Festa del Grazie is the next lead.
-

Milestone

Level reached: 2 **Trigger:** The PCs find Sergius's letter in Room 5 and deliver it to Sir Gorim Vel.

DM Notes

- Gorim can accompany the PCs or wait outside (“I’m not going down into the sewers, I’ve got sciatica”). Convincing him requires **Persuasion DC 17**. If he accompanies them, he comments on everything with exasperation.
 - No encounter should be lethal. If the PCs are struggling with Grunzio, have him slip on something comedic.
 - Ermolao can become a recurring NPC that the PCs find in improbable places in later episodes.
 - The unionized rats can return as a running gag: they’re found protesting in the square during the Festa del Grazie.
-

Episode Closing - Return to the Taberna

DM Notes

The PCs climb out of the sewers and show the letter to Gorim. He reads it, turns red in the face, rereads it, turns it over as if there might be something on the back.

Read to the players

Gorim stares at the letter in silence for an embarrassingly long time. Then he folds it carefully, tucks it into his belt, and looks at you.

“Good. You didn’t find the ring. You found a problem. Which is worse.”

He pulls out a coin purse, weighs it in his hand, sighs deeply, and counts out half the agreed sum - one coin at a time, with the face of someone donating a kidney.

“Here. Half. You earn the rest by continuing to work for me. This ‘S’ - whoever they are - needs to be found. And the ring needs to be recovered. At the Festa del Grazie, the letter says? Good. We’ll be there.”

Pause.

“And this time try not to come back empty-handed.”

DM Notes

The PCs receive half the sum agreed in the negotiation. If they had agreed on 50 gp, they receive 25. If they had agreed on 30, they receive 15. And so on. Gorim counts every coin with visible pain.

This binds the PCs to Gorim for the following episodes - they must continue working for him to get the rest. The hook for Episode 2 (the Festa del Grazie) is established.

△ Auto-translated from Italian. The Italian version is the source of truth.

Episode 2 - The Village Festival

Description

The Festa del Grazie is the event of the year in Fianus Romanus. Stalls, competitions, food, music, and the whole village in the square. The PCs arrive broke, hungry, and with a letter from “S” that promises something - or maybe not. Sergius is here, somewhere, and he’s having fun.

Objective

Stated: Find “S” at the Festa del Grazie, as the letter says. **Actual:** Sergius doesn’t let himself be found - he leaves another clue/taunt. The PCs meet new NPCs, get into trouble, and discover something about Sergius’s clandestine trade.

The Week Before the Festival

DM Notes

Quick montage - not a full session. Each PC picks an odd job from the table, makes a roll, gets paid. 10-15 minutes of play at most. The point is to establish that they’re broke and the Festival is their only hope.

The PCs have **10 gp** (Gorim’s advance). Rent is 4 gp/day. In a week they need 28 gp. They need to earn at least 18.

Read to the players

A week passes. A week of moving turnips, washing floors, chasing rats, and off-key singing at the Taberna. Domina Lella keeps your tab - every evening, punctual, she reminds you how much you owe. The amount changes every time.

Available Odd Jobs

Odd Job	Pay	Roll	Notes
Moving crates for merchants	2 gp/day	STR DC 8	
A bard PC plays at the Taberna	1-3 gp/evening	Performance DC 12	Domina Lella takes 50%
Night watch pre-Festival	3 gp/night	-	Boring. Possible suspicious sighting (Sergius?)
Deliveries around the village	2 gp/delivery	-	Way to meet new NPCs
Hunting rats in cellars	1 gp/rat	Easy combat	The unionized rats protest

Each PC can work 5-6 days. With some luck they reach 25-30 gp - just barely enough.

Festival Day

Map: [../maps/LaFestaDelGrazie.png](#) (Mercato Centrale square during the Festa del Grazie)

Read to the players

The Mercato Centrale is unrecognizable. Colored flags hang from every window, the aroma of roast meat and fresh bread covers (almost) the village's usual smell. Stalls everywhere: fruit, fabrics, amulets of dubious authenticity, a guy selling "the authentic treasure map of the Count" (he has six different ones). Children run between the legs of the crowd, an off-key bard sings on an improvised stage, and somewhere someone is already arguing about the price of onions.

Sir Gorim Vel stands in the center of the square looking like someone who'd rather be anywhere else. He has a list in hand and is trying to organize something. It's not going well.

Festival Attractions

Attraction	Type	Description
Archery contest	Competition	3 shots, DEX (Ranged Weapons). Prize: 5 gp to the winner
Arm wrestling contest	Competition	STR (Athletics) progressive DC: 10, 13, 16. Prize: 3 gp
The onion ring	Gag	A stall sells “the Count’s Ring” - it’s a fried onion ring. 1 cp. Gorim is furious.
The off-key bard	Roleplay	A bard PC can challenge him. Opposed Performance. The loser buys drinks.
The Count’s lottery	Gag/clue	Tickets for 1 gp. The prize is “an audience with the Count.” Nobody has ever won. Nobody knows if the Count actually exists.
Terzilio’s stall	Roleplay	Turnips and onions, but today also “special Festival turnips” (they’re normal turnips, triple the price)

New NPCs

Flavia “La Biscia”

Traveling merchant, arrives from out of town for the Festival. Stat block: **Commoner** (MM p. 345). Sells fabrics, ribbons, and “exotic perfumes” (colored water). Talks extremely fast, changes subject every three seconds, impossible to follow. Knows everything about everyone because she travels between villages and collects gossip.

- **Trait:** talks without ever taking a breath, changes topic mid-sentence
- **Usefulness:** source of information about trade in the area - might know something about merchandise arriving by sea
- **Secret:** buys goods from a mysterious supplier who operates via the sewers (Sergius?)

Mastro Cecio

Village blacksmith, enormous, silent. Stat block: **Commoner** (MM p. 345), STR 18. Speaks in sentences of three words maximum. Respected by everyone. Judges the arm wrestling contest.

- **Trait:** three words maximum per sentence (“Good.” “Not bad.” “Go away.”)

- **Usefulness:** knows the sewers because he worked there years ago repairing grates. Knows there's "weird stuff" down there
- **Secret:** has seen someone entering the sewers at night, but doesn't care

Donna Ortensia

Minor noble, wife of an official. Stat block: **Noble** (MM p. 348). Organizes the Festival (badly). Wants everything to be perfect, nothing is. Complains about everything in a shrill voice. The equivalent of Lopez: understands nothing but has decision-making power.

- **Trait:** "This won't do. Redo everything." (about anything)
- **Usefulness:** has access to the Count's castle (she's the only civilian who enters)
- **Secret:** she's a client of Sergius (buys embarrassing merchandise). Terrified it'll come out.

La Contessina - Magnifica Vien dal Porto

The Count's wife. Stat block: **Noble** (MM p. 348). Arrives at the Festival in a carriage - "*La Contessina vien dal porto*" (The Countess comes from the port), everyone says with a mix of terror and resignation.

Born in **Vetusta Portus**, the seaside hamlet of Fianus. Her father was a dockworker at the port. She was a common woman whom the Count married after getting her pregnant. Now she puts on airs of a grand lady but never had the qualities for it. Prudish, bigoted, faux-cultured - she speaks in pseudo-refined words full of malapropisms. She's the one who had the "*Gabella Pudicitiae*" imposed after discovering the Count's portrait. Disliked by everyone, including Gorim.

- **Trait:** speaks in a pompous and incorrect manner. Every sentence contains at least one malapropism delivered with absolute confidence.
- **Usefulness:** she's the cause of the *Gabella Pudicitiae*. If the PCs understand her role, they understand why Sergius has it in for the Count.
- **Secret:** she's afraid the Count's portrait will surface - not for the Count's sake, but for her own. If it comes out that the Count bought "certain things," her reputation as a virtuous woman is finished.

Typical phrases: - "*I am a woman of great moralitude, not like some others.*" - "*These things are an offense to public decency and to my personal sensibillitude. They give me the nerves.*" - "*The Count, my husband, is a man of mirrored rectitude - and whoever says otherwise is a defamator and a professional calumniator, and I'll sue them.*" - "*I come from a humble but honorific family. My father was a... a maritime entrepreneur.*" (dockworker) - "*I will not tolerate these... these... obscenitudes! Away!*"

Away with all of it!" - (to Gorim) "You should do more to protect the reputability of this family, instead of standing there eating." - (to the PCs) "And who would you be? Adventurers? Shady people, surely. You can tell by the look of you."

Flavia "La Biscia"

The village old woman who knows everything about everyone. Stat block: **Commoner** (MM p. 345). The equivalent of Itala. Always sitting in the same corner of the square, apparently asleep, actually listening to everything.

- **Trait:** seems to be sleeping, then comments with surgical precision on something said 10 minutes earlier
- **Usefulness:** has known Sergius since he was a legitimate merchant. Knows about the old symbol. Could connect the double S to Sergius - but only if asked the right questions.
- **Secret:** none. Knows everything and has nothing to hide. This makes her terrifying.

The Encounter with La Contessina

DM Notes

While the PCs wander the Festival with Gorim, a flashy carriage arrives in the square. Gorim sees it and curses under his breath: *"No. No no no. Not today."*

Read to the players

A golden carriage - or at least recently repainted gold, judging by the drips - stops in the center of the square. Out steps a woman in a dress too elaborate for a village festival and a hat that defies the laws of physics. She looks around with the air of someone who just stepped in something unpleasant.

Gorim stiffens. "La Contessina", he mutters through his teeth. "Magnifica Vien dal Porto. Act natural, maybe she won't-"

"GORIM!"

Too late.

DM Notes

La Contessina greets Gorim with fake cordiality. Gorim secretly hates her but must be respectful - she's the Count's wife.

While they talk, La Contessina notices something at the Festival that scandalizes her - a stall with decorative nymph statuettes (slightly undressed), or a painting of a bather, or simply a woman with a low neckline. Something absolutely harmless.

Read to the players

La Contessina freezes. She stares at the stall. Her face turns crimson.

"And WHAT is THIS?! Gorim! What is this stuff?! These... these obscenities in the square, in front of children, in front of EVERYONE?! Don't you know there's the Gabella Pudicitiae for exactly this?! I had it put in place! ME! To protect the moralitude of this village! And what do you do? NOTHING!"

She turns to the PCs.

"And who would you be? Adventurers? Shady people, surely. You can tell by the look of you."

Gorim, with the face of someone counting to ten: "Contessina, these are... collaborators. Of the Count."

"Collaborators? The Count didn't tell me anything. As usual. Anyway - get that stuff out of the square. NOW. Or I'll have everything shut down."

She storms off toward another stall to inspect.

DM Notes

The PCs now know that: - There exists a **Gabella Pudicitiae** - a tax/ban on "indecent goods" - La Contessina had it imposed - Gorim detests her but can't say so - La Contessina is the Count's wife (and therefore the indirect cause of Sergius's problems)

If the PCs ask Gorim about the Gabella Pudicitiae after La Contessina leaves:

Gorim sighs: "The Gabella Pudicitiae. The tax on... on stuff. That stuff. She wanted it. Ever since she found out that the Count... well, never mind. Point is, now if you sell anything that La Contessina considers 'indecent' - and she considers a bare elbow indecent - you pay triple taxes. And you have to declare who buys it. DECLARE. You understand? Nobody buys anything anymore."

Sergius's Clue - The Speech

DM Notes

Grigius Voidus, the grey official organizing the Festa del Grazie, is supposed to give the opening speech. Stat block: **Noble** (MM p. 348, CR 1/8). Sergius gagged him before the speech and took his place, in disguise.

The speech starts as a nonsensical ramble about quails and gratitude, then derails into allusions to Sergius's trade and veiled accusations against the Count.

Read to the players - The Speech

The official climbs onto the stage. The crowd falls silent. He clears his throat.

"Citizens of Fianus Romanus! On this solemn Festa del Grazie, it is my duty and privilege to remind you of the profound meaning of this celebration. The quails. Yes, the quails. Because without the quails, ladies and gentlemen, where would we be? The quails nourish us, the quails inspire us, the quails represent everything good this village has to offer. And we must be grateful. Grateful to the quails. Grateful to the harvest. Grateful to His Excellency the Count of..."

Pause. Smile.

"...whose name is on the tip of everyone's tongue, as always."

Chuckle in the crowd.

"But let's talk about serious matters. Let's talk about trade. About those fine products that arrive by sea and that certain gentlemen - I won't name names, but I salute them - purchase with such discretion. L'Assedio Notturmo (The Night Siege), for instance. An excellent tonic, I'm told. Or perhaps you prefer La Rocca Imponente (The Imposing Fortress)? I hear it's very popular among officials. And what about La Bandiera al Vento (The Flag in the Wind) - the favorite of those who need... courage, shall we say, in the nighttime hours."

Silence in the square. The notables have gone white.

"And then there are the figurative arts. Beautiful portraits. Heroic. Some commissioned by very high-placed individuals - so high they never paid the bill. What a shame. The artist still has the work. Carefully preserved."

Long pause. Looks at the crowd.

"But I'm not here to cause a scandal. I'm here to play a game. The Count's Ring - yes, that one - is still in circulation. And it will go to whoever can follow the trail. The clues are already in place. Look where the Count never looks. Look where virtue is sold by weight. Look where the rats have more dignity than the nobles."

Theatrical bow.

"Happy Festa del Graz-"

He stops. A commotion from the blacksmith's shop. Someone shouts. The "official" looks toward the noise, smiles, and steps off the stage, slipping into the crowd. When someone tries to follow him, he's already gone.

The Real Grigius Voidus

He's found in the blacksmith's storeroom, gagged but unharmed. He didn't see who attacked him. He only heard a voice saying: *"Nothing personal. Well, a little bit."*

Grigius is shocked and indignant. He doesn't understand what happened. He wants to file a complaint but doesn't know against whom.

After the Speech - Terzilio

DM Notes

Timeline: At the start of the Festival, Sergius was in the square disguised as Terzilio (at the turnip stall). Then he changed to disguise himself as Grigius Voidus and give the speech. The real Terzilio arrives late to the Festival - he wasn't gagged, he's simply late (he's Terzilio, after all).

When the PCs meet him after the speech, it's the **real** Terzilio. He's never seen them - it was Sergius in Episode 1.

Read to the players

Among the stalls you find Terzilio, the greengrocer. He's setting up his stall in a hurry - he arrived late. Turnips and onions with a sign "FESTIVAL TURNIPS - SPECIAL PRICE" (triple the price).

DM Notes

If the PCs say something like "Terzilio, we saw each other last week" or "thanks for showing us the trapdoor":

Terzilio looks at them puzzled: "Me? You? Never seen you before. Want some turnips?"

He's not lying - he really has never seen them. This is the first clue that the Terzilio from Episode 1 wasn't the real Terzilio. The PCs probably won't catch it right away, but the seed is planted.

The Treasure Hunt

The clues in the speech send the PCs on a treasure hunt through the village. Three stops, prize at the end.

DM Notes

The PCs must decipher the three phrases from the speech. Each phrase indicates a location. At each location they find a note with the double S, a coin prize, and the clue for the next stop. If the PCs get stuck, Festival NPCs can help (Flavia in particular).

Stop 1 - "Where the Count never looks"

Solution: The public notice board in the square - the Count never reads citizens' complaints. Investigation DC 10 or any village NPC confirms it.

What they find: Behind an old notice, an envelope with the double S. Inside a note: *"Well done. You're not entirely useless. Now look where virtue is sold by weight. - S."*

Stop 2 - "Where virtue is sold by weight"

Solution: The spice/herb stall at the market - it's where the "herbs" for vigor potions were sold before the ban. Investigation DC 12, or Flavia "La Biscia" knows, or Flavia laughs and points to the stall.

What they find: Hidden in a sack of aromatic herbs, an envelope with the double S. Inside a note: *"Almost there. The last clue is where the rats have more dignity than the nobles. - S."*

Stop 3 - "Where the rats have more dignity than the nobles"

Solution: The **unionized rats'** stand in the square - the 5 rats with their accessories have a tiny stand with an illegible sign and a petition. They're the only ones in the square who openly say what they think, without hypocrisy. Investigation DC 13, or the PC with Speak with Animals asks the rats (who cooperate willingly - "Finally someone who takes us seriously!").

What they find: Under the rats' stand, a leather tube with the double S. Inside: - An empty vial with a label: *"La Rocca Imponente - for the moments that count"* (logo: a halberd poking out of a bush - the brand of "L'Immane Alabarda") - A scroll of parchment: a fragment of the **Count's portrait** - just a corner, enough to tell it's an "artistic" portrait but not enough to identify the subject - A note: *"The rest of the portrait is safe. If your master wants it back, he knows where to find me. But I doubt he has the courage. - S."* - A second note, in different handwriting, more hurried: *"I am not your adversary, good sirs. The day will come when you'll understand which side to be on. And that day, I assure you, it won't be your master's side."* - A pouch with **3 gp**

DM Notes - Sergius Watches

While the PCs read the note, a PC with passive Perception ≥ 14 (or Perception DC 14 if someone looks around) notices a figure in the shadow of a nearby alley. Standing still, watching them. When they make eye contact, the figure gives a small theatrical bow - the same one from the speech on stage - and slips into the alley.

If the PCs pursue: the confrontation scene with Sergius (see § Sergius - if spotted). He whistles, 3 Thugs arrive, he vanishes.

If they don't pursue: the figure is already gone. But the PCs know that "S" was watching them. He's studying them.

The Economic Contrast

Source	How much they gave the PCs
Gorim ("Giorgio")	1 gp (in 10 sp, with pain)
Sergius (treasure hunt prize)	3 gp (all at the end)

The villain pays 3 times better than the employer.

Sergius - If Spotted

DM Notes

No combat is planned for this episode. The only exception is if the PCs spot Sergius (in disguise). In that case:

How they can spot him: - Notice that the "official" on stage has working hands (not a noble's) - Perception DC 16 - Follow someone who disappears into an alley after the speech - opposed Stealth - At Stop 3, passive Perception ≥ 14 to notice the figure watching them

If they confront him: Sergius has **1 turn** before vanishing. As he vanishes, he whistles - and **3 Thugs** (MM p. 350, CR 1/2) emerge from the crowd. They were disguised as porters/merchants. They cover Sergius's escape.

Combat - 3 Thugs:

Encounter difficulty: HARD (4 PCs lv2)

Name	No.	HP	AC	Attack	Notes
Thug (MM p. 350)	3	32	11 (leather armor)	+4 melee, 1d6+2 (mace) × 2 (Multiattack)	Pack Tactics

- They block the PCs to prevent pursuit
- After **1 round**, or as soon as at least **2 are wounded**, the most wounded one flees

- The others fight until surrender or KO
- They don't fight to the death - if cornered they surrender ("They don't pay us enough for this!")

Sergius (if hit before vanishing):

AC	HP	Speed	Notes
14	18	30 ft.	Doesn't counterattack. Uses Ring of Shadows (Invisibility, bonus action in combat) and vanishes.

Sergius meanwhile: uses the Ring of Shadows (Invisibility) and vanishes. The PCs hear footsteps receding, then nothing. It's not possible to capture him.

If the PCs capture a Thug: he knows little. "Some guy paid us 5 gp each to act tough if anyone followed him. We never saw his face. He contacted us with a note." The note has the double S.

If the PCs don't spot Sergius: no combat. The Festival ends peacefully.

The Unionized Rats at the Festival

The 5 rats (with their accessories) are in the square. They have a tiny stand with an illegible sign. They're protesting. Nobody pays attention except the PCs.

If the PC with Speak with Animals talks to them: they're protesting the Festival's sanitary conditions. They want a representative on the village council. They have a petition with 47 signatures (paw prints).

Rewards

Treasure Hunt Loot

- **Gold:** 3 gp (prize at Stop 3) + odd jobs from the week
- **Items:** Empty vial of "La Rocca Imponente" (halberd/bush logo of "L'Immane Alabarda"), fragment of the Count's portrait

- **Information:** “S” sold vigor potions and erotic portraits. The Count was a client. Someone imposed a tax on the merchandise. “S” has a compromising portrait of the Count. Terzilio might not always be Terzilio.

Milestone

Level reached: (none - the milestone is in Episode 3)

Episode Closing - Return to the Taberna

DM Notes

The PCs return to the Taberna with the portrait fragment and the vial. Gorim is furious about the public speech. He wants the complete portrait - if Sergius makes it public, the Count is finished.

Read to the players

Gorim is waiting for you at the Taberna. He has the face of someone who just chewed a whole lemon.

“Did you see it? DID YOU SEE IT?! That... that criminal got on stage and... in front of EVERYONE...”

He sits down. Takes his head in his hands.

“The portrait. If that portrait comes out, the Count is finished. La Contessina will kill him. The council will depose him. And I... I’ll be out of a job.”

He looks at you.

“You need to find out who this ‘S’ is. And you need to find that portrait. Before he uses it.”

Pause.

“And no, I’m not paying you more.”

DM Notes

The hook for Episode 3: discover who “S” is and recover the portrait. Gorim doesn’t know who it is - the PCs must investigate. Possible leads: - The vial of “La Rocca Imponente” with the halberd/bush logo → someone in the village recognizes the logo of “L’Immane Alabarda” - Flavia knows the company but not the owner’s name - Donna Ortensia was a client - might know more but is afraid to talk - Captured Thugs (if any) know little but the note has the double S

DM Notes

- The Festival is a pure roleplay session - no combat planned (unless they spot Sergius).
- Sergius is present at the Festival **disguised as Terzilio** (see PlanBook § Sergius). The real Terzilio is also at the Festival with his stall. The DM must decide in which scenes it's the real Terzilio and in which it's Sergius. Note for consistency.
- Donna Ortensia is the key to accessing the castle in later episodes.
- Flavia is the key to connecting the double S to Sergius - but only if the PCs ask the right questions.
- The portrait fragment is the key item that launches Episode 3.